mortars had to be deployed to cover the bridges on the Nam Ka Chu. Dalvi also expressly told the battery commander that the mortars were not to fire unless he personally gave the order. As a result, Nijjar was in Brigade HQ on the morning of 20 October. But he was unable to establish contact with his battery, which was standing by resolutely. Despite the fact that there were 450 rounds stacked up and ready to fire, not a single heavy mortar was fired in the Nam Ka Chu battle. In fact, other than 2 Rajput and perhaps the 9 Punjab Company at Bridge 5, no one seemed ready for a fight.

On the evening of 19 October, the CO of 1/9 GR, Lieutenant Colonel B. S. Ahluwalia, was certainly not privy to the general assessment that the battle was coming. The Gorkha Battalion HQ situated behind the Tsangdhar Ridge did not have direct visual contact with the Chinese and Ahluwalia himself had not seen the enemy preparations on the banks of the Nam Ka Chu. Lieutenant Colonel K. K. Tewari, the divisional signals officer, had been in the mess bunker during Dalvi's emotional conversation with Prasad. Tewari had then moved to the 1/9 GR position where he spent the night. Yet nothing of the assessment was communicated to Ahluwalia, who continued to be unaware of the impending attack. He was only asked to send a company to Bridge 5 in the morning due to 'orders from above'. From their commanding positions, the Gorkhas too had been watching the feverish Chinese activity, but the CO's assessment was that it was nothing but a show of force to frighten the Indians. On the other hand, his company commanders and JCOs thought otherwise, for they asked the men to prime their grenades in anticipation of a night or dawn attack. When the CO came to know, he ordered the men to un-prime their grenades. The Gorkhas were also told that they must not do anything that would escalate the situation. For good measure, Ahluwalia also issued orders that no sub-unit or individual could open fire without his personal orders.

Despite the relative commanding position of 1/9 GR, their defences were quite perfunctory and far from adequate. Though they were the only battalion to have been tactically sited some 200 metres up the spur from the river, the frozen ground was extremely rocky. Unable to dig in without entrenching tools, the only defences the Gorkhas could muster were low sangars, with no overhead protection other than parachutes salvaged from the drop zone that were draped over the stonework.

Chinese activity through the night remained undetected. The battalion conducted its usual morning stand-to at 5 a.m. One column was about to